

O-Level English — Continuous Writing Blueprint

Syllabus 1184 | Paper 1 Section C | 30 Marks (Content 10 + Language 20)

Exam Requirement: Choose 1 of 4 topics and write 350–500 words in continuous prose.

Topics may cover different types of texts, e.g. narrative or argument, and may include hybrid question types.

Chapter 1 Assessment Overview

Assessment Overview

Section A — Marking Criteria

Continuous Writing is worth **30 marks** in total, split into two assessment criteria: **Content (10 marks)** and **Language (20 marks)**. Understanding this split is essential — Language carries twice the weight of Content.

Content assesses whether you have addressed all aspects of the task with sufficient development. **Language** assesses organisation of ideas, clarity of expression, and accuracy of language including vocabulary, grammar, punctuation and spelling. To reach the top band, you need excellence in both.

Content Band Descriptors

Band	Descriptor
5	All aspects of the task are addressed fully and convincingly.
4	All aspects of the task are addressed with clear development.
3	Some aspects of the task are addressed with some development.
2	Some aspects of the task are addressed.
1	Some attempts to address the task.

Language Band Descriptors

Band	Descriptor
5	Coherent presentation of ideas across the whole response. Wide vocabulary and grammar structures; complex structures used accurately.
4	Coherent presentation of ideas with some cohesion between paragraphs. Vocabulary and grammar structures sufficiently varied to convey shades of meaning; generally accurate language use.
3	Most ideas coherently presented with some cohesion within paragraphs. Vocabulary and grammar structures sufficiently varied to convey intended meaning; generally accurate language use.
2	Some ideas coherently presented with attempts at achieving cohesion. Mostly simple vocabulary and grammar structures; meaning is usually clear; some instances of accuracy.
1	Ideas presented simply. Simple vocabulary and grammar structures; limited examples of correct language use.

Key Point. To score Band 5, every paragraph must directly and fully address the question (Content), and your writing must demonstrate cohesive paragraph flow, ambitious vocabulary, varied sentence structures and consistently accurate grammar (Language). Both criteria must be strong — a well-argued essay with many language errors will not reach the top band.

Section B — Question Types

The official 1184 syllabus states that topics may cover **different types of texts**. It also notes that essays may take the form of a **combination of these forms**. In practice, schools and teachers commonly identify five question types, listed below. Be aware that blending two or more types is increasingly common and should be prepared for.

Type	Description	Signal Words
Narrative	Tell a story based on a given prompt. Use first-person narration and include vivid descriptions of events, people and emotions.	“Write about a time when...”, “Describe what happened when...”
Descriptive-Reflective	Describe a person, place or object in detail, then explain its significance to you.	“Describe...and explain why...”, “Why is it important?”
Personal-Reflective	Share your personal views or experiences on a topic, supported by anecdotes.	“Which do you prefer?”, “How true has this been for you?”
Discursive	Present a balanced discussion of a topic, covering multiple perspectives with examples.	“What are the advantages and disadvantages?”, “What features...?”
Argumentative	Take a clear stand on an issue and defend it with logical arguments and evidence.	“Do you agree?”, “What are your views?”, “What is your opinion?”

Question Selection Test. Before committing to a question, apply this three-part test: (1) Do you have enough knowledge and examples for the topic? (2) Can you think of at least 3–4 solid points or plot events? (3) Do you feel confident writing in the required style (narrative, argumentative, etc.)? If you cannot answer yes to all three, move on to another question.

Chapter 2 Universal Writing Process

Universal Writing Process

Section A — Seven Steps for Every Essay

Follow these seven steps every time you write a continuous writing essay, regardless of question type.

Question Type 1: Analyse the Question

Technique: Read the question carefully before writing a single word; misreading costs marks.

1. Underline all key words. Identify the question type.
2. Check for absolute terms (*always, never, must*) which usually require a nuanced response.
3. Determine exactly what the question is asking you to do.

Question Type 2: Take a Stand or Choose a Storyline

Technique: Decide your position or plot before writing; this keeps the essay focused.

1. For argumentative and reflective essays, decide your position before writing.
2. For narratives, decide your storyline and moral.
3. Your stand must appear in your introduction and remain consistent throughout.

Question Type 3: Plan Before Writing

Technique: A brief outline prevents rambling and ensures coherence.

1. Sketch a brief outline: introduction, 3 body paragraphs, conclusion.
2. For each body paragraph, note the main point, one example and the link back.
3. Planning prevents rambling and ensures coherence. Spend 3–5 minutes on this.

Question Type 4: Write a Strong Introduction

Technique: Your introduction must capture attention, clarify key terms and state your stand.

1. Capture attention with a lead-in (hook).
2. Clarify key terms if needed.
3. State your stand or thesis clearly.

Question Type 5: Develop Body Paragraphs Using P-E-E-L

Technique: Each body paragraph follows Point, Elaboration, Example, Link.

1. State your **Point** in one clear sentence.
2. **Elaborate:** explain the reasoning; fill all logical gaps.
3. Provide a specific, relevant **Example**.
4. **Link** back to the topic sentence using signal words (*hence, therefore, thus, as a result*).
5. Each paragraph should be roughly 80–120 words and focus on one main idea.

Question Type 6: Write a Strong Conclusion

Technique: Summarise your key arguments or reflect on the story's significance; end on a strong note.

1. Summarise your key arguments or reflect on the significance of your story.
2. End on a strong note.
3. Never introduce new points in the conclusion.

Question Type 7: Proofread

Technique: Use the final 3–5 minutes to check grammar, tense, word count and contractions.

1. Check for tense consistency, subject-verb agreement, spelling errors and sentence fragments.
2. Ensure you have not used contractions.
3. Verify that your essay stays within 350–500 words.

Common Mistake. Many students begin writing immediately and run out of ideas halfway through. Always spend 3–5 minutes planning. A clear outline prevents disorganised essays and saves time in the long run.

Chapter 3 Paragraph Structure and Evidence

Paragraph Structure and Evidence

Section A — The P-E-E-L Framework

P-E-E-L is the backbone of every strong body paragraph, especially in argumentative and discursive essays. Each component must be present for the paragraph to be convincing.

Component	Description
Point	State your main argument in one clear sentence. It must directly address the question.
Elaboration	Explain your point in detail. Show the reasoning behind your claim. Fill all logical gaps so the reader can follow your argument without questioning it.
Example	Provide a specific, relevant example to support your point. Good examples are accurate (include details), representative (not limited to one context) and relevant (directly supports the point).
Link	Wrap up the paragraph by connecting it back to your topic sentence. Use signal words such as <i>hence</i> , <i>therefore</i> , <i>thus</i> or <i>as a result</i> .

What is a Logical Gap? A logical gap is a flaw in your reasoning where you skip an important step in your explanation. This makes your argument less convincing because readers can question whether your claim is actually true.

After writing your elaboration, ask: “If someone read only this paragraph, would they be fully convinced?” If there is any step where the reader might ask “But why?” or “How does that follow?”, you have a logical gap. Add the missing explanation before moving on.

Section B — Using Evidence Effectively

Principle	What to Do	Why It Matters
Be specific	Include specific details such as names, dates and statistics.	Read current affairs regularly. Note down key facts and figures.
Be representative	Use examples from different countries and contexts, not only Singapore.	Prepare a bank of examples covering local, regional and global events.
Be relevant	The example must directly support your point.	After writing your example, re-read your topic sentence. Does the example prove it?

Note. If you cannot think of a real-world example, a well-reasoned hypothetical scenario is better than no example at all. However, real examples with specific details will always score higher.

Chapter 4 Writing Strong Introductions

Writing Strong Introductions

Section A — Components of an Introduction

A strong introduction serves three purposes: it captures the reader’s attention, clarifies key terms and states your position or thesis.

Component	Description
Lead-in (Hook)	An opening hook that draws the reader in. This is the first sentence or two of your essay.
Clarification	If the question contains key terms that could be interpreted in different ways, briefly define or clarify them.
Thesis Statement	State whether you agree or disagree (for argumentative essays), or outline your main arguments briefly.

Section B — Types of Lead-in

Question Type 1: Current Affairs / Relevance

Technique: Explain why the topic matters in today’s world; this is the most reliable approach.

1. Explain why the topic matters in today’s world.
2. State what the consequences are, or why it is worth debating.

Question Type 2: Rhetorical Question

Technique: Pose a thought-provoking question that the reader is not expected to answer.

1. Pose a thought-provoking question that the reader is not expected to answer.
2. This engages the reader by prompting them to think deeper about the issue.

Question Type 3: Quotation

Technique: Use a well-known quote only if you can remember it accurately and attribute it correctly.

1. Only use this if you can clearly remember the quote and attribute it correctly.
2. Misquoting or making up quotes will hurt your credibility.

Question Type 4: Anecdote or Humour

Technique: Make a light-hearted observation about the topic; appropriate only for less serious topics.

1. Make a light-hearted observation about the topic.
2. Only appropriate for less serious topics.
3. Avoid humour when discussing issues like poverty, war or discrimination.

Section C — Handling Absolute Statements

An **absolute statement** contains words like *always*, *never*, *must*, *definitely* or *all*. In most cases, you should reject the absolute statement because few issues are entirely black or white. Instead, set conditions: state when the claim holds true and when it does not. Your conditions must appear in your thesis statement.

Why nuance matters. Agreeing that something is “always” or “never” the case leaves you vulnerable. The examiner can easily think of exceptions. A nuanced stand with conditions is almost always stronger and shows mature thinking.

Chapter 5 Question-Type Guides

Question-Type Guides

Section A — Narrative

Question Type 1: Planning and Structuring a Narrative

Technique: Identify the key emotion or event, then plan a focused five-paragraph structure.

1. **Analyse the question.** Look for emotion words (e.g. *regretted*, *proudest*, *disappointed*) and action words (e.g. *write about a time when*). These define the focus.
2. **Choose a specific, realistic event.** Keep the plot within a short time frame (a few hours to a few days). The experience must be believable for a teenager in Singapore.
3. **Select a narrative structure.** (a) Chronological — tell events in order; (b) Flashback — begin in the present, then go back; (c) Begin at the climax — open with the most intense moment, then explain how you got there. Options (b) and (c) tend to create more engaging openings.
4. **Plan your five paragraphs.** (1) Opening scene or hook; (2) Build-up and context; (3) Climax or turning point; (4) Resolution or aftermath; (5) Reflection and lesson learned.
5. **Mark moments for “Show Don’t Tell”.** Identify 2–3 moments where you will describe emotions through physical actions and sensory details.
6. **Plan your language devices.** Include personification, similes, metaphors and idioms. Use dialogue where appropriate.
7. **End with a reflection.** Your final paragraph should reflect on what you learned and connect to a broader insight about life.

Question Type 2: Show Don’t Tell

Technique: Describe feelings through physical actions and sensory details rather than stating the emotion directly.

1. Identify the emotion you want to convey (e.g. fear, joy, anger).
2. Replace the direct statement (e.g. “She was nervous”) with physical actions, bodily sensations and sensory details.
3. Use figurative language (similes, metaphors, personification) to deepen the description.

Worked Example 1 (Fear)

Emotion: Fear

Telling version: She was scared.

Showing version: Her throat went dry and her palms moistened as beads of sweat rolled down her face.

Worked Example 2 (Sadness)

Emotion: Sadness

Telling version: She was sad.

Showing version: Her lips began to tremble as a wave of emotion overcame her. She turned her face away and began to sob.

Worked Example 3 (Anger)**Emotion: Anger****Telling version:** She was angry.**Showing version:** She pursed her lips and clenched her fists. Her breathing became heavier as she stared at the person who had betrayed her.**Worked Example 4 (Joy)****Emotion: Joy****Telling version:** She was happy.**Showing version:** Unable to contain her joy, she jumped up and threw a fist in the air.**Worked Example 5 (Generosity)****Trait: Generosity****Telling version:** He was generous.**Showing version:** He never hesitated to place the largest note in his wallet into the donation tin, often leaving himself with just enough for the bus ride home.**Worked Example 6 (Calm)****Emotion: Calm / Relief****Telling version:** He felt calm.**Showing version:** A gentle breeze rustled through the leaves overhead, and the only sound was the distant hum of cicadas. I closed my eyes and felt the tension drain from my shoulders.**Narrative Idioms and Their Usage**

Idiom	Meaning	Best Used When
Every cloud has a silver lining	Something bad at first turns out to be good	Near the reflection or resolution
Bite the bullet	Face a difficult situation with courage	At the climax when a tough decision is made
Cross that bridge when we come to it	Deal with a problem only when it arises	When a character postpones a worry
A watershed moment	A moment that changes everything	To signal the climax
Learn the hard way	Learn from a painful experience	In the reflection paragraph
A wake-up call	An event that alerts someone to a problem	When the character suddenly realises the truth
Swallow one's pride	Do something despite feeling embarrassed	When the character must humble themselves
The last straw	The final event that causes a reaction	To describe what triggered the climax

Narrative Sentence Templates

Position	Template
Opening	“It was a [adj.] [day/morning/evening] when [inciting event].” “Little did I know that [ordinary event] would change the way I saw [topic] forever.” “If someone had told me a year ago that I would [key event], I would not have believed them.” “The memory of that [day/moment/encounter] remains etched in my mind to this day.”
Emotion	“My heart pounded against my chest as [situation].” “A wave of [emotion] washed over me as I [action].” “I could feel my cheeks burning with [embarrassment/shame/anger] as [what happened].” “Unable to contain my [joy/relief/frustration], I [physical action].” “My hands trembled as I [action], the weight of [the moment/the decision] pressing down on me.”
Resolution	“As the dust settled, I realised that [consequence].” “It was only then that [turning point or resolution].” “Slowly, [describe how the situation was resolved].”
Reflection	“Looking back, I realise that [lesson learned].” “This experience taught me that [moral or insight], a lesson I carry with me to this day.” “In retrospect, [event] was not merely [surface description] but a turning point that [deeper significance].” “As I reflect on this experience, I am reminded that [broader life lesson].”

Note. Show Don't Tell is not limited to narratives. In Descriptive-Reflective essays, show significance through a brief anecdote or sensory detail. In Personal-Reflective essays, show the impact through a specific moment. Showing is always more convincing than telling, regardless of essay type.

Narrative Endings. End your narrative with a reflection or moral lesson. The best endings connect the experience to a broader insight about life, showing the examiner that you can think beyond the surface of the story.

Section B — Descriptive-Reflective

These questions always have two parts: (a) a **description** of a person, place or object and (b) a **reflection** explaining its importance or significance to you.

Question Type 1: Planning and Structuring a Descriptive-Reflective Essay

Technique: Underline both the description and reflection components, then plan to address both with equal weight.

1. **Identify both components.** Underline the description component (e.g. “Describe a place...”) and the reflection component (e.g. “Why is it important?”). Both parts must be addressed.
2. **Choose a strong subject.** Select a person, place or object with genuine personal significance. Avoid generic choices.
3. **Choose a structure.** Option A — describe first, then reflect (Introduction; Full description; Anecdote; Reflection 1; Reflection 2; Conclusion). Option B — combine description and reflection in each paragraph. Option B is generally more cohesive.
4. **Plan sensory details.** Note which senses you will appeal to in each paragraph: sight, sound, smell, touch or taste. Aim to use at least three different senses.
5. **Plan camera angles.** Alternate between wide-angle descriptions (panning, setting the scene) and close-up details (zooming, specific features).
6. **Plan the reflection.** Go beyond “It is important to me because I like it.” Explain why the subject matters on a deeper level.
7. **Write the conclusion.** Summarise why the subject is meaningful and express a forward-looking thought.

Common Mistake. Spending too much time on description and rushing the reflection (or vice versa). Both parts carry equal importance. As a guide, roughly half your essay should be descriptive and half should be reflective.

Descriptive-Reflective Sentence Templates

Position	Template
Opening	“Of all the [people/places/possessions] in my life, [subject] holds a special place in my heart.” “When I think of [subject], a flood of memories comes rushing back.” “There is one [person/place/object] that I will never forget — [subject].”
Description	“The first thing that strikes you about [subject] is [vivid visual detail].” “I can still recall the [sound/smell/texture] of [specific sensory detail], which always reminded me of [association].” “What made [subject] truly special was [unique quality or quirk].”
Reflection	“This [feature/quality] is significant to me because [personal reflection explaining why it matters].” “Whenever I [interact with/visit/look at] [subject], I am reminded of [deeper personal meaning].”
Anecdote	“I remember one occasion when [specific anecdote involving the subject].” “It was during [event] that I truly understood how much [subject] meant to me.” “This particular memory stands out because [reason it is significant].”
Conclusion	“[Subject] is not merely [physical description]; it represents [deeper significance].” “As the years pass, my appreciation for [subject] only grows stronger because [reason].” “I know that [subject] will continue to [inspire/comfort/remind] me of [closing thought].”

Section C — Personal-Reflective

Personal-reflective essays require a **balance between personal anecdote and thoughtful reflection**. If you lean too far towards personal anecdotes, the essay reads like a narrative. If you lean too far towards theory, it fails to address the personal aspect of the question.

Question Type 1: Planning and Structuring a Personal-Reflective Essay

Technique: Identify signal phrases in the question, form a thesis, then balance personal anecdote with analysis in each body paragraph.

1. **Identify question type.** Look for phrases like “Which do you prefer?”, “How true has this been for you?” or “Write about some occasions when...”.
2. **Form a thesis.** Even for personal-reflective essays, a thesis statement gives your essay direction. Every paragraph must support this thesis.
3. **Choose a structure.**
 - *Preference questions* (“Which do you prefer?”): Introduction; Reason 1 + anecdote; Reason 2 + anecdote; Reason 3 or exception; Conclusion.
 - *Truth questions* (“How true has this been for you?”): Introduction; Why true/untrue + anecdote; Why true/untrue + anecdote; Exception or contrasting circumstance; Conclusion.
4. **Add specific anecdotes.** For each body paragraph, include a specific personal experience. Use past tense for anecdotes and present tense for general observations.
5. **Write in first person throughout.** Use “I” and “my”. Do not generalise to all people or adopt a preachy tone.
6. **Maintain high language standards.** Continue to use idioms, proverbs, metaphors, similes and persuasive language.
7. **Write a meaningful conclusion.** Summarise your position and end with a personal insight that only you could have arrived at through your experiences.

Balance Check. If your essay reads like a narrative with no analysis, it is too personal. If it reads like an argumentative essay with no personal anecdotes, it is too theoretical. Aim for a balance: each body paragraph should contain a personal experience AND a thoughtful reflection on what it means.

Personal-Reflective Sentence Templates

Position	Template
Opening	“[Topic] is a matter I have thought about deeply, and I firmly believe that [your position].” “Having experienced [relevant personal context], I am of the opinion that [your position].” “While others may see this differently, my personal experience has shown me that [thesis statement].”
Body	“One reason I feel this way is that [reason]. I experienced this first-hand when [specific anecdote].” “Reflecting on my own life, I recall a time when [anecdote]. This experience reinforced my belief that [link to thesis].” “[Anecdote in past tense]. Looking back, this taught me that [reflection in present tense].” “This is especially meaningful to me because [personal connection].”
Concession	“That said, I acknowledge that there are situations where [contrasting circumstance].” “While my experience has led me to this view, I recognise that others may feel differently because [reason].” “However, even in such cases, I maintain that [restate thesis with nuance].”
Conclusion	“In the end, my experiences have taught me that [summary of key lesson].” “[Topic] may be viewed differently by different people, but for me, [personal closing insight].” “As I continue to grow, I am confident that [forward-looking personal resolution].”

Section D — Discursive

A discursive essay presents **multiple perspectives on a topic**. Unlike an argumentative essay, you do not need to take a strong stand. Instead, you explore advantages and disadvantages, or different perspectives on a topic.

Question Type 1: Planning and Structuring a Discursive Essay

Technique: Identify what the question asks you to discuss, select four balanced points, and apply varied paragraph strategies.

1. **Identify the discussion focus.** Determine whether the question asks for advantages and disadvantages, features, causes, effects, or ways to address something.
2. **Select four strong points.** Your points must be: (a) mature and sophisticated; (b) balanced between general and specific; (c) varied but logically linked.
3. **Structure your essay.** Introduction: hook, state the importance, and provide a thesis summarising your 4 points. Body: 2 advantages and 2 disadvantages, each in its own P-E-E-L paragraph. Conclusion: restate your points and end positively.
4. **Choose a paragraph strategy.** Select the strategy that best fits each point (see table below).
5. **Vary your paragraph openings.** Do not start every paragraph with “The first advantage is...”. Use varied openings.
6. **Develop each paragraph fully.** State your point, elaborate with a chosen strategy, support with a specific example, and link back.
7. **Write a positive conclusion.** Restate your four points briefly. Use the formula: “If [suggest a way to manage the drawbacks], the benefits of [topic] can be maximised and [positive outcome].”

Paragraph Development Strategies

Strategy	Description
Past to Present	Contrast how things were in the past with how they are now.
Cause to Effect	Explain what causes something and describe its consequences.
Mind-set to Action	Show how a particular belief or attitude leads to a certain behaviour.
Problem to Solution	Identify a problem and suggest a practical way to address it.
Strategy to Benefit	Describe a method or approach and explain why it is useful.
Problem to Impact	Describe a challenge and analyse the severity of its effects.
Trend to Interpretation	Identify a trend and explain what it reveals about society.

Discursive vs Argumentative. If the question asks “What are the advantages and disadvantages?” or “What features...?”, write a discursive essay. If the question asks “Do you agree?” or “What are your views?”, write an argumentative essay. Getting this distinction wrong will affect your Content marks.

Discursive Sentence Templates

Position	Template
Opening	“In today’s increasingly [globalised/digital/interconnected] world, the issue of [topic] has become more pressing than ever.”
Thesis	“Few issues have sparked as much debate in recent years as [topic].” “While [topic] offers significant benefits such as [Point 1] and [Point 2], there are also notable drawbacks including [Point 3] and [Point 4].”
Advantage	<i>Point:</i> “A significant benefit of [topic] is that [main argument].” <i>Elaboration:</i> “This is because [reason], which in turn leads to [consequence].” <i>Example:</i> “A clear illustration of this can be seen in [example with specific details].” <i>Link:</i> “Hence, it is evident that [summary] is a meaningful advantage of [topic].”
Disadvantage	<i>Point:</i> “While [topic] has its merits, it should be noted that [drawback].” <i>Elaboration:</i> “The underlying reason for this is that [explanation].” <i>Example:</i> “This is evidenced by [specific case], which demonstrates that [link to point].” <i>Link:</i> “As a result, [summary] remains a valid concern when considering [topic].”
Conclusion	“In conclusion, [topic] brings both benefits and drawbacks. While [summary of advantages], [summary of disadvantages] cannot be ignored.” “If [suggest a way to manage the drawbacks], the benefits of [topic] can be maximised and [positive outcome].” “Moving forward, it is essential that [stakeholders] strike a balance between [benefit] and [risk] so that [desired outcome].”

Section E — Argumentative

An argumentative essay requires you to **take a clear stand** and **defend it with logical arguments and evidence**. This is arguably the most structured question type and rewards careful planning.

Question Type 1: Planning and Structuring an Argumentative Essay

Technique: Read the question, form a nuanced thesis, then develop it using Method 2 (two supporting arguments plus one counter-argument with rebuttal).

1. **Analyse the question.** Check for absolute words (*always, never, must, definitely, all*). If present, take a nuanced stand with conditions.
2. **Form your stand.** Ask: Do I instinctively agree or disagree? What are the reasons? Are there exceptions? Aim for a nuanced position rather than a simple “I agree” or “I disagree”.
3. **Write your thesis first.** It should state your position and preview your main arguments.
4. **Select a structure.**
 - Method 1 (Full Support): 3 supporting arguments.
 - Method 2 (With Counter-Argument): 2 supporting arguments + 1 counter-argument with rebuttal. *Recommended.*
 - Method 3 (Nuanced Stand): 3 varied points exploring different dimensions of the issue.
5. **Plan each body paragraph.** Note your Point, key Elaboration, Example, and Link sentence. Ensure there are no logical gaps.
6. **Construct your counter-argument and rebuttal.** (a) State the opposing point; (b) Explain their reasoning; (c) Explain why their argument is flawed or limited; (d) Link back to your own stand.
7. **Write a strong conclusion.** Reaffirm your stand in different words. Summarise key arguments. End with a strong closing statement or call to action.

Essay Structures at a Glance

Method 2 (With Counter-Argument)	Method 3 (Nuanced Stand)
1. Introduction (agree/disagree)	1. Introduction (nuanced thesis)
2. Supporting Argument 1	2. Point 1
3. Supporting Argument 2	3. Point 2
4. Counter-Argument + Rebuttal	4. Point 3
5. Conclusion	5. Conclusion

Stay consistent. Once you take a stand, every body paragraph must support it. Do not contradict yourself by agreeing in one paragraph and then disagreeing in the next. Avoid using the words “agree” and “disagree” more than once to prevent sounding repetitive.

Argumentative Sentence Templates

Position	Template
Lead-in	“In a world where [relevant trend], can we afford to ignore the impact of [topic]?” “With the rapid advancement of [technology/social media/globalisation], the question of [topic] demands serious consideration.”
Stand	“I am of the opinion that [your position], and I will argue this on the grounds of [Point 1], [Point 2] and [Point 3].”
Stand (nuanced)	“To a large extent, I [agree/disagree] with the statement. However, it is important to recognise that [condition or exception].”
Body	<i>Point:</i> “One compelling reason to support this view is that [main argument].” <i>Elaboration:</i> “When we consider the fact that [supporting detail], it becomes clear that [conclusion].” <i>Example:</i> “For instance, [example with specific details such as names, dates or statistics].” <i>Link:</i> “Therefore, [point] is a strong reason to [agree with/disagree with] the statement.”
Counter-argument	<i>Acknowledge:</i> “Admittedly, some may argue that [opposing point].” <i>Rationale:</i> “They put forward this idea because [reason for their belief].” <i>Rebuttal:</i> “However, this argument overlooks the fact that [your rebuttal].” <i>Rebuttal:</i> “While there is some merit to this claim, I would argue that [your stronger point].”
Conclusion	“In light of the arguments presented, it is clear that [restate thesis in different words].” “All in all, [summary of 2–3 key points] firmly support the position that [thesis].” “If [suggest a solution or action], the [positive outcome] can be realised.” “Ultimately, the responsibility lies with [individuals/governments/society] to ensure that [positive resolution].”

On Templates. Examiners can recognise memorised chunks of text. These templates should serve as structural scaffolding that you fill in with your own ideas, vocabulary and examples. The strongest essays use these frameworks naturally without sounding rehearsed.

Chapter 6 Hybrid Questions

Hybrid Questions

Section A — What Is a Hybrid Question?

The O-Level exam increasingly sets hybrid questions that blend two or more question types. These require you to combine skills from different categories in a single essay. Being prepared for hybrid formats is essential.

Common Hybrid Combinations

Combination	Example Question
Narrative + Personal-Reflective	“Write about a time when you discovered something unexpected about yourself. What did you learn from the experience?”
Narrative + Argumentative	“Write about a time you had to defend an unpopular belief to your friends. Did you feel that sticking to your principles was the right thing to do?”
Descriptive + Personal-Reflective	“Describe a place that has changed significantly over the years. Why does this change matter to you?”
Personal-Reflective + Discursive	“Some people feel that failure is the best teacher. How true has this been in your experience, and do you think it applies to everyone?”

Section B — Approach to Hybrid Questions

Question Type 1: Structuring a Hybrid Essay

Technique: Identify both components, then choose Block Structure or Weave Structure to address both fully.

- Identify both components.** Underline the key words. Determine which two question types are present. Ask: Which part requires storytelling or description? Which part requires analysis, reflection, or argument?
- Choose a structure.**
 - Option 1 — Block Structure (A, A, B, B, Conclusion):* Devote the first half of your body paragraphs to one component and the second half to the other (e.g. Paragraphs 2–3 for Narrative, Paragraphs 4–5 for Argument). Recommended when the two components are clearly distinct.
 - Option 2 — Weave Structure (A+B, A+B, A+B, Conclusion):* Combine both components within every body paragraph. Each paragraph describes a moment and immediately reflects on its meaning. Recommended for greater cohesion and flow.
- Apply the relevant techniques.** Refer to the step-by-step guides for both question types.

Most Common Mistake. Addressing one part fully while rushing the other. If the question asks you to narrate AND argue, both the story and the argument must be well developed. Neither should feel like an afterthought.

Worked Example 1 (Narrative + Argumentative Hybrid)

Question: “Write about a time you had to defend an unpopular belief to your friends. Did you feel that sticking to your principles was the right thing to do?”

Paragraph 1 — Introduction (Hook + Thesis): Open with a hook that sets the scene. Briefly foreshadow the conflict and state your thesis: e.g. “This experience taught me that standing by one’s beliefs, though difficult, is always worthwhile.”

Paragraph 2 — Build-up (Narrative): Set the context using Show Don’t Tell. Describe the situation, the people involved and the rising tension. Use sensory details and dialogue.

Paragraph 3 — Climax (Narrative): Describe the moment you defended your belief. Show the emotional intensity through physical actions and reactions.

Paragraph 4 — Argument (P-E-E-L): Step back from the story. Present your argument for why sticking to principles was the right choice. State your point, elaborate with reasoning, support with the narrative as your example, and link back to your thesis.

Paragraph 5 — Conclusion (Reflection + Restatement): Reflect on what you learned. Restate your thesis in new words. End with a broader insight about integrity or conviction.

Hybrid as Opportunity. If a question does not fit neatly into one category, it is likely a hybrid. This is not a problem — it is an opportunity. Hybrid essays allow you to demonstrate a wider range of skills, which can impress the examiner if both components are well executed.

Chapter 7 Language and Grammar

Language and Grammar

Section A — Common Grammar Rules

Rule	Explanation
Tense consistency	Use past tense for narratives. Use present tense for argumentative and discursive essays when discussing general truths.
No contractions	Never use contractions (<i>don't</i> , <i>won't</i> , <i>can't</i>) in formal essays. Write the words out in full.
Subject-verb agreement	Use the one-S tip: if the subject has an S (plural), the verb does not, and vice versa.
Complete sentences	Every sentence must have a subject and a verb. Fragments like “Running as fast as she could” are not sentences.
No comma splices	Do not connect multiple clauses with only commas. Use full stops, semicolons or linking words.
Avoid sentence starters	Avoid beginning sentences with <i>And</i> , <i>But</i> or <i>So</i> . Use <i>However</i> , <i>Furthermore</i> or <i>Additionally</i> instead.
Uncountable nouns	Remember: <i>advice</i> (not <i>advices</i>), <i>equipment</i> (not <i>equipments</i>), <i>staff</i> (not <i>staffs</i>), <i>elderly people</i> (not <i>elderlies</i>).
Pronoun clarity	Ensure all pronouns (<i>it</i> , <i>they</i> , <i>them</i> , <i>this</i> , <i>that</i>) clearly refer to a specific noun. If the reader could be confused, replace the pronoun with the noun itself.
Articles	Use <i>a</i> or <i>an</i> when mentioning something for the first time. Use <i>the</i> when both you and the reader know exactly which one you mean. Omit articles before uncountable nouns in a general sense (e.g. “Education is important,” not “The education is important”).

Section B — Sentence Variety

After you finish writing, review your sentences for variety. Using only simple sentences throughout makes your essay feel monotonous and will cost marks. Include the following structures at least once per paragraph.

Structure	Example
Subordinate clause (contrast)	Although technology has its benefits, we should not ignore its drawbacks.
Relative clause	Mobile devices, which teenagers are obsessed with, can be both harmful and helpful.
Participial phrase (past)	Caused by the release of greenhouse gases, global warming is one of the world's most pressing problems.
Participial phrase (present)	Believing that all students can learn, teachers continue to work hard despite challenges.
Complex time clause	After he had made sure no one was watching, he dashed across the parade square.

Section C — Connectors and Discourse Markers

Function	Examples
Adding	Additionally, Furthermore, Moreover, In addition, Apart from, Besides, Not only... but also
Contrasting	However, Conversely, On the contrary, In contrast, Although, Even though, Yet, That being said
Cause and effect	Thus, Therefore, Hence, As a result, Consequently, Since, Because
Opinion	In my opinion, I strongly believe, I am of the opinion that, I would argue that, I personally feel that
Qualification	Perhaps, Probably, One possible explanation is, It could be the case that, It appears to be
Assertion	It is undeniable that, It is evident that, It is hardly surprising that, It is safe to assume that
Exemplification	For instance, For example, A case in point is, To illustrate this point
Conclusion	In conclusion, All in all, Ultimately, On the whole, To sum up

Section D — Vocabulary Upgrading

Replace common, overused words with more precise alternatives. The table below is organised by essay type so you can quickly find vocabulary suited to your question.

Argumentative and Discursive Vocabulary

Instead of	Use
good	beneficial, advantageous, commendable, favourable, constructive
bad	detrimental, adverse, harmful, undesirable, problematic
important	pivotal, salient, paramount, significant, crucial, indispensable
very	exceedingly, remarkably, profoundly, considerably, immensely
think	believe, maintain, contend, assert, am of the opinion that
many	numerous, a multitude of, a significant number of, countless
show	demonstrate, illustrate, exemplify, underscore, highlight
get	obtain, acquire, attain, secure, gain
I agree	I concur, I am of the firm opinion that, I subscribe to the view that
I disagree	I take issue with, I contest the claim that, I am unconvinced that
problem	predicament, dilemma, pressing concern, systemic issue
solution	remedy, countermeasure, viable approach, pragmatic strategy
because of	owing to, on account of, as a consequence of, in light of
in conclusion	in the final analysis, taking all factors into account, on balance

Narrative and Descriptive Vocabulary

Category	Words
Happy	elated, overjoyed, euphoric, exhilarated, jubilant
Sad	melancholy, pensive, crestfallen, despondent, disheartened
Angry	infuriated, incensed, seething, indignant, exasperated
Afraid	petrified, apprehensive, terror-stricken, paralysed with fear
Movement	trudged, sauntered, staggered, ambled, strode
Speech	murmured, exclaimed, remarked, declared, whispered, retorted
Beauty	breathtaking, resplendent, picturesque, striking, captivating
Age	ancient, weathered, time-worn, dilapidated, venerable

Vocabulary Strategy. Do not force every word to be sophisticated — this makes your writing feel unnatural. Aim to use 4–6 high-value vocabulary words per essay, placed at key moments such as your thesis statement, topic sentences and concluding line. The rest of your essay should flow naturally.

Chapter 8 Writing Strong Conclusions

Writing Strong Conclusions

Section A — What a Strong Conclusion Must Do

Your conclusion is the last thing the examiner reads. A strong conclusion leaves a lasting impression. A weak conclusion undermines the rest of your essay.

A strong conclusion must:

1. Restate your main points or thesis in different words (never copy your introduction word for word).
2. Provide a final reflection, recommendation or call to action.
3. End on a strong, memorable note.

Conclusion Strategies by Question Type

Question Type	Strategy
Narrative	Reflect on the significance of the experience and the lesson learned.
Descriptive-Reflective	Restate why the subject matters and express a forward-looking thought.
Personal-Reflective	Summarise your position and end with a personal insight or resolution.
Discursive	Restate both sides briefly. End positively by suggesting how drawbacks can be managed.
Argumentative	Reaffirm your stand firmly. End with a strong closing statement or call to action.

Critical Rule. Never bring up a new argument or idea in your conclusion. The conclusion is for wrapping up, not for adding content. If you think of a new point, it belongs in the body of the essay.

Chapter 9 Exam Strategy

Exam Strategy

Section A — Time Management

Paper 1 is 1 hour 50 minutes for all three sections (Editing, Situational Writing and Continuous Writing). Allocate roughly **45–50 minutes** for Continuous Writing.

Time Allocation for Continuous Writing

Stage	Time	Notes
Planning	5–7 min	Outline only; do not write prose yet
Introduction	5 min	Hook, clarification, thesis
Body Paragraph 1	7 min	P-E-E-L
Body Paragraph 2	7 min	P-E-E-L
Body Paragraph 3	7 min	P-E-E-L
Conclusion	4–5 min	Restate, reflect, end strongly
Proofreading	3–5 min	Grammar, tense, contractions, word count
Total	≈48 min	Leaves ≈62 min for Sections A and B

Section B — Quick Checklist

Item	Target
Word count	400–500 words (minimum 350)
Paragraph count	5 (introduction + 3 body + conclusion)
Body paragraph length	80–120 words each
Tone	Formal; first-person only in Personal-Reflective and Narrative; no slang
Vocabulary	4–6 high-value words per essay
Grammar check	Tense consistency, SVA, articles, no contractions, complete sentences

Section C — Long-Term Preparation

Build a Current Affairs Bank. Read current affairs regularly from news apps, newspapers or reliable online sources. Prepare a bank of examples covering local, regional and global topics for common essay themes such as technology, education, environment, media and social issues.

Prepare for Unusual Formats. Increasingly, the O-Level exam includes hybrid or unusual question formats. If you encounter an unfamiliar question type, analyse the key words carefully, determine what skills the question is testing, and plan your approach before writing.